

ABSTRACT:

Name of Responsible Researcher:	Dr. Anahí Urquiza
Proposal Title:	Science-policy interfaces and scenario construction in Chile: How to better bridge scientific evidence with policy-making? An inter-transdisciplinary challenge for environmental complex problems.

Contemporary society has grown increasingly dependent on the creation of spaces for the inclusion of scientific knowledge in political and decision-making processes. In fact, the generation and strengthening of science-based decision-making spaces has become during the last few decades in a policy goal in itself. This has occurred on a discursive level, as well as on the elaboration of regional, national, and transnational strategic development plans.

This concern has been particularly intense on the fields of environmental policy and Climate Change. These problems are defined by a high level of uncertainty in planning efforts, involving a high degree of both urgency and risk given their complex, systemic, multi-level and non-linear nature. In this context, the construction and modelling of scenarios has acquired a key relevance, insofar they allow decision-makers to better understand the changes they face, timely detect emerging problems, and identify coping strategies.

The study of the interface between science and policy through the construction and modelling of scenarios has garnered noticeable attention in the last few decades, especially in Germany, the United States, Canada, and the United Kingdom, where academia has had a relevant role in policy-formulation processes. In comparison, in the Chilean case studies are very limited, even when the evidence is vast regarding the uncoupling between the regulation and funding systems in science, directed primarily at evaluating the publication of indexed papers by university academics and the expectations regarding the strengthening the integration between scientific activity and public policy. In turn, evidence points towards observing that the scientific knowledge used in decision-making is very limited, with little presence of scientific institutions and a limited influence on decision-making processes.

On this direction, there are yet to appear efforts of analyzing critically the processes of construction and modelling of scenarios, considering the integration of Inter-transdisciplinary knowledge in the context of the interface between science and policy, that is, between research institutions and decision-making organisms related to climate change and environmental problem. The present project takes as its aim to move forward in this direction through (i) the identification of the main factors influencing the construction and modelling of scenarios based on the examination of global and Latin-American experiences, (ii) the description of its expression in Chile in the fields of climate change and environmental problem, paying close attention to the last 10 years, (iii) the in-depth analysis of at least four national cases in these topics, paying attention to their epistemological, normative, and pragmatic differences in their treatment of uncertainty in political and scientific fields, (iv) the explanation of their peculiarities regarding global and Latin-American experiences and, lastly, (v) the identification of facilitating and obstructing factors for the development of the science-policy interface in Chile.

To achieve these objectives, the proposed study employs the Sequential Mixed Method, which consists of the usage of qualitative and quantitative techniques for the recollection and analysis of data, so as to draw upon their complementary advantages and reach a better comprehension of the phenomenon being studied. The study considers in this regard three stages: (1) Theoretical framework and comparative study of the configuration of the science-policy interface on an international level; (2) Study of public policy and Chilean Interface cases; and (3) Integration and compared analysis. On the first stage, an in-depth analysis of the national and international literature will be carried out, identifying the main aspects affecting the configuration of the science-policy interface. In the next step, the evolution of the governance regulation the interface between science and policy in Chile during the past ten years will be studied, to allow the examination of the processes of configuration of this kind of spaces in different fields of action. Finally, these results will be compared with the types priorly identified, distinguishing facilitators and obstructing factors for the strengthening of the interface between science and policy at a national level.